

CSCI 421 – Computer Issues Seminar

Spring 2026

January 26 – May 13

Class Meeting Time: Mondays, 7:30–10:20 pm

Course Description

This course explores a wide variety of ethical, personal, moral, legal, economic, and societal issues raised by computer technology. Topics may include ethics, artificial intelligence, privacy and surveillance, social media, intellectual property, cybersecurity, automation, robotics, genetic engineering, and the role of the computer state.

Exploration will occur through essays, articles, videos, case studies, student presentations, writing, debate, and sustained discussion. The course is designed to widen our sphere of knowledge and interest, stimulate sincere and thoughtful conversation, and cultivate ethical reasoning skills. Particular attention will be given to identifying and articulating ethical dimensions of technology-related issues using multiple frameworks, including deontological, utilitarian, justice-based (John Rawls), and economic perspectives.

Course Outcomes

This course emphasizes outcomes 2 and 3 of the CSCI program:

- Students will be prepared for lifelong learning in computing, including experience with self-directed inquiry.
- Students will strive to uphold the highest standards of conduct in their professional and personal lives, including ethical reasoning, responsibility, and integrity.
- Students will be able to analyze technology-related dilemmas from individual, societal, and global perspectives.

Course Structure (7:30–10:20 pm Seminar)

This course meets once weekly for 3.5 hours, and attendance is essential. Each class session will be structured to balance discussion, reflection, and active engagement.

A typical class session will include:

- Opening framing question and check-in
- Journal-based small-group and full-class discussion
- Short instructor-led framing or case overview
- Breaks for rest and movement
- Student presentations, debates, or applied activities

- Closing synthesis and preview of the weekly journal prompt

Because this is an evening seminar, the course emphasizes discussion, case studies, and student participation over extended lectures.

Required Texts

- Spinello, *CyberEthics: Morality and Law in Cyberspace* (6th ed.)
- Kidder, *How Good People Make Tough Choices* (Revised Edition)

Additional articles and videos will be provided or linked throughout the term.

Assignments & Evaluation

- Weekly Journals (300–500 words): 15%
- Discussions, debates, and active participation: 15%
- Ethical Case Presentation: 40%
- Final Ethics Paper (10–15 pages): 30%

Weekly Journals

Weekly journal entries are a central component of the course. The purpose of the journals is learning by writing — one of the pillars of this seminar. Journals should reflect thoughtful engagement with the week's readings, media, and discussion.

If you wish a journal entry to be treated with complete confidentiality, please indicate this clearly at the top of the entry, and that request will be honored.

Weekly Schedule, Topics, and Assignments

Week 1 – Why Ethics in Computing?

Read: CyberEthics Ch. 1; Kidder Ch. 1–2

Watch: The Moral Bias Behind Your Technology (TED); What Is Computer Ethics? (Computerphile)

Journal: Describe a technology you rely on that may conflict with your values.

Week 2 – Ethical Frameworks: Duties, Outcomes, Justice, and Cost

Read: Kidder Ch. 3–5; Overview of utilitarianism and deontology; John Rawls – Justice as Fairness; Ethical limits of cost–benefit analysis

Watch: Harvard Justice (Rawls & fairness); CrashCourse Philosophy (utilitarianism/deontology); CrashCourse Economics (cost–benefit analysis)

Journal: Evaluate a technology using utilitarianism, deontology, Justice as Fairness, and economic benefits and constraints.

Week 3 – Privacy, Surveillance, and Data Ownership

Read: CyberEthics Privacy chapter; Zuboff excerpt

Watch: The Age of Big Data (PBS); Data Brokers (John Oliver)

Journal: Is privacy a right, a commodity, or an illusion?

Week 4 – Social Media, Persuasion, and Manipulation

Read: CyberEthics Social Media chapter; Tristan Harris article

Watch: The Social Dilemma clips

Journal: When does persuasion become manipulation?

Week 5 – Free Speech & Content Moderation

Read: CyberEthics Free Speech chapter; Section 230 explainer

Watch: Who Decides What Gets Taken Down? (Vox)

Journal: Should platforms act as publishers or utilities?

Week 6 – Intellectual Property, Creativity, and AI

Read: CyberEthics IP chapter; AI copyright article

Watch: Copyright in the Digital Age (Computerphile)

Journal: Can AI plagiarize?

Week 7 – Artificial Intelligence, Bias, and Fairness

Read: CyberEthics AI chapter; Weapons of Math Destruction excerpt

Watch: Fighting Bias in Algorithms (TED)

Journal: Who is responsible for algorithmic harm?

Week 8 – Student Presentations I

Journal: Reflection on a peer presentation.

Week 9 – Cybersecurity, Hacking, and Ethics

Read: CyberEthics Security chapter; hacking case study

Watch: Ethical Hacking (Computerphile)

Journal: When is hacking justified?

Week 10 – The Computer State and Digital Power

Read: CyberEthics government sections; surveillance article

Watch: Digital Authoritarianism (DW/Vox)

Journal: How does technology change power relationships?

Week 11 – Automation, Robotics, and the Future of Work

Read: CyberEthics automation chapter

Watch: Humans Need Not Apply (CGP Grey)

Journal: What do we owe displaced workers?

Week 12 – Bioethics and Genetic Engineering

Read: CyberEthics genetic engineering; CRISPR ethics overview

Watch: Genetic Engineering Explained (Kurzgesagt)

Journal: Where should society draw the line on enhancement?

Week 13 – Student Presentations II

Journal: Most urgent ethical issue discussed.

Week 14 – Responsibility and Moral Agency in AI

Read: CyberEthics AI responsibility

Watch: Who Is Responsible for AI Decisions? (Computerphile)

Journal: Can machines be moral agents?

Week 15 – Ethics Paper Workshop

Read: Sample ethics papers

Journal: What ethical tension is central to your paper?

Week 16 – Integration and Reflection

Final Journal: How has your thinking about technology and ethics changed?